Estm8 Strategic Brief

Problem, Category, Messaging & Story

Executive Summary

The UK joinery industry is in crisis. Nearly 4,000 construction companies went insolvent in the past 12 months. Specialist subcontractors — joineries — are hit hardest. The survivors will be those who can see where their money goes. The rest will continue flying blind until they hit the ground.

Estm8 is a CRM, tender, and production management system built by a joiner, for joineries. It closes the loop between what's quoted and what's real — giving owners and estimators visibility they've never had.

This brief defines the problem we're solving, the category we're creating, the story we're telling, and the language we'll use to tell it.

Part One: The Industry Context

A Sector in Structural Distress

The UK joinery and woodworking sector is experiencing what analysts call a "perfect storm" — rising insolvencies, supply chain fragmentation, and persistent economic headwinds. This is not a temporary dip. It is a structural reckoning.

The Numbers

Insolvency Crisis:

- 3,973 construction insolvencies in the 12 months to July 2025 — up 23.5% vs pre-COVID levels
- Construction accounts for 17.4% of all corporate insolvencies in the country
- Insolvency rate: 52.6 per 10,000 companies
- Specialist subcontractors (joineries, carpenters, finishers) account for the highest number of failures
- 195 specialist firms went insolvent in July 2025 alone
- Compulsory liquidations up 11% year-on-year — creditors are no longer willing to wait

Cost Pressures:

- Building costs predicted to rise 15% by end of the decade
- UK manufacturers pay 4x more for electricity than US counterparts

- Industrial electricity prices 46% above global average
- 15% of electricity bills are policy levies

Labour Crisis:

- 35% of the construction workforce is over 50
- Only 20% is under 30
- 750,000 construction workers will retire by 2036
- The industry needs to recruit nearly 1 million additional workers by 2032
- Demand for carpenters and joiners needs to increase by 11%

Supply Chain Collapse:

- National Timber Group — the UK's largest independent timber distributor — collapsed in November 2025
- 561 immediate redundancies
- 13+ branch closures across Scotland and England
- Hundreds of smaller joineries left exposed to supply disruption and credit contraction

The Fixed-Price Trap

Joinery is a trade of fixed-price contracts. A firm tenders for a project months or years in advance, pricing based on material and labour costs at the time of tender. Perhaps they add a small contingency.

Then the world changes.

Material costs spike. Energy bills double. Wages inflate. But the contract price doesn't move.

The Mathematics of Failure:

Consider a joinery that signed a contract in January 2024 for delivery in January 2025:

- Revenue: Fixed at £100,000
- Estimated Cost (Jan 2024): £90,000 (projected £10k profit)
- Realised Cost (Jan 2025): Due to energy spikes and wage inflation, costs rise to £105,000
- Result: A £5,000 loss on a project that consumes factory capacity for months

For a joinery operating on 2-5% margins, a 15% cost increase is mathematically terminal.

The Credit Crunch

Trade credit insurance — the oil that keeps the supply chain turning — is being withdrawn across the sector.

Insurers are reducing credit limits or withdrawing cover entirely for construction firms.

The Vicious Cycle:

When insurers withdraw cover for a joinery, suppliers stop offering credit. They demand cash on delivery. This destroys the joiner's working capital cycle. They must pay for materials months before they get paid by their client.

This "cash gap" is a leading cause of insolvency for profitable firms. They don't run out of work; they run out of cash.

The Verdict

> "They don't run out of work; they run out of cash."

The insolvency data we see in 2025 is often a lagging indicator of inflation that occurred in 2023 and 2024. Many firms burned through their cash reserves to honour legacy fixed-price contracts during the initial inflation spikes, hoping to recoup losses on future work. By 2025, those reserves are exhausted.

The firms that survive this period will be "leaner, more technologically advanced, and more contractually savvy." The rest will not.

This is not a prediction. It's a filter. The market is selecting for visibility.

Part Two: The Problem

Blind Tendering

Joineries don't know where their money goes.

This is not a technology problem. It's not an efficiency problem. It's a **visibility** problem that has been normalised across an entire industry.

The problem isn't that joineries are bad at estimating. The problem is that they're not estimating at all. They're just pricing.

Estimates have lost their meaning. What joineries call an "estimate" is just a number to win the work — with no forecast of what it will actually cost to deliver. The £500 cabinet isn't an estimate of materials plus labour plus margin. It's a price pulled from memory and gut feel.

The £50m Joinery: A Case Study in Blindness

We visited a joinery turning over £50m in revenue. We asked how they estimate.

They used the example of a cabinet carcass costing £500.

We challenged: how much of that is materials? How much is labour? What's the margin?

They couldn't answer.

The owner said: "*I've been in this game for 30 years. I know it'll be alright at £500.*"

The Challenge

We pointed out: materials might be £100 in January and £200 in December. But your blanket pricing of £500 means you're accepting the margin loss without even understanding it.

You're either:

- Pricing to allow for the margin loss — which puts you at a competitive disadvantage, or
- Taking on risk you can't see

The owner kind of laughed it off. Said the business analyst out there would say different.

The Disconnect

He's hired someone to find the problem, but he's not connecting himself to the cause.

The £500k gap lives in a spreadsheet somewhere. The £500 cabinet lives in his hands, his experience, his identity. And the two don't touch.

That's the defence mechanism: "*I do the work. Someone else does the numbers.*"

The Identity Problem

Thirty years in the game. Built the business. Knows joinery cold. The £500 gut-call isn't just a pricing method — it's proof of his expertise.

If we come in and say "your gut is wrong," we're not critiquing a process. We're threatening something deeper.

But here's what's telling: he *hired* a business analyst. He knows something's off. He just can't — or won't — trace it back to his own decisions.

The real challenge: **How do we let him keep his identity as the expert, while showing him his expertise is being wasted on guesswork?**

Not "you're wrong." But "you're flying a plane with no instruments, and you're good enough that you've survived — but you shouldn't have to."

The Annual Review

This same joinery owner said they sit down once a year to review who their best and worst customers and subcontractors are.

When challenged about why only once a year, he couldn't answer with anything specific other than that's the time they collate the data.

Not because that's the right cadence. Because that's how long it takes to see anything.

The £500k Gap

That same joinery has hired a business analyst to identify a £500k gap in their profit.

The gap didn't arrive one day as a surprise. It accumulated invisibly, tender by tender, across years of decisions that all felt "alright."

Thousands of £500 decisions. None of them understood. All of them compounding.

The Disconnected Loop

The core dysfunction: **estimates are completely disconnected from production.**

Estimates Are Not Estimates

What joineries call "estimates" are not estimates at all. They don't forecast the material and labour required to produce the tender items. They don't predict what the job will actually cost to deliver.

They're pricing quotes designed to win work, with no regard for the realism of delivering it.

Anticipated margins are calculated once at estimate creation and not measured again until tender completion. What happens throughout remains invisible.

Production Is Not Tracked

Jobs go in and jobs go out. But joineries have no idea how long specific jobs take, or where bottlenecks lie.

The £50m joinery doesn't monitor production. They have no visibility into where time actually goes.

The Gulf of Understanding

This creates a gulf of understanding. Most joineries operate blind, not understanding where costs or bottlenecks in manufacture exist.

The result: lower margins than anticipated, often resulting in profit loss.

When a job goes wrong — costs more than expected, takes longer than planned — they can rarely trace it back to the estimate. At best it would be a partial picture.

It just feels like bad luck. A difficult client. A problem on the floor. Something that "went wrong" without a clear origin.

Learning Is Impossible

Without data connecting what was quoted to what actually happened, the same mistakes repeat invisibly.

They can't learn because there's nothing to learn from. The data doesn't exist. A job goes badly and it's just... a bad job. A feeling. A story. "That one was a nightmare." But no one can say where the nightmare started or what

it cost.

Every new tender is priced with the same blindness as the last one.

The Back-to-Front Jigsaw

How Tenders Arrive

Tenders arrive in the form of a tender pack containing drawings, schedules of work, pricing schedules, and specifications. These documents are often nested, complex, and inconsistent — written by architects in various formats with reference after reference.

The estimator must piece together what the architect actually wants from fragments scattered across documents.

The Jigsaw Metaphor

It's like a back-to-front jigsaw.

Everyone else gets the picture on the box and finds where the pieces go. The estimator gets a pile of pieces and has to *discover* what they're even building before they can price it.

They spend hours looking at drawings, then cross-referencing those drawings to specifications, making notes, building a picture of each job in the tender.

Only once the picture is clear — only once they've done all that unpaid detective work — can they start the job they were actually hired for.

Where the Time Goes

The estimator we met at the £50m business was very clear: he doesn't have enough time.

But it wasn't just volume. It was the trawling through complex nested specification documents that registered with him most.

Hours spent excavating architect documents like archaeological digs. Clause 4.3 which points to Appendix B which points to British Standard 1234 which has been superseded by something else.

By the time you've *understood* what they're asking for, you've used up the time you needed to *improve* how you'd deliver it.

What Should Happen

Estimators should produce a takeoff, material list, and labour calculation.

What Actually Happens

In reality, they normally review what they have against a previous job and add a margin.

The £500 cabinet isn't 30 years of expertise. It's a memory of a different job, with a guess on top.

So the jigsaw work doesn't even produce a real estimate. It produces just enough understanding to say "this looks like that one" — and then the number is inherited, not calculated.

Which means:

- If the old job was priced wrong, the new job is priced wrong
- If materials have changed, nobody knows
- If this job has hidden complexity the old one didn't, it won't show up until production
- The "margin" they add is a buffer against uncertainty they can't see

The Gambling

They don't walk away from complex tenders often. They normally just guess a price and take on the risk.

Every complex tender becomes a gamble. The specs are nested, the deadline is tight, so they guess a price based on what it "feels like" and submit. Win or lose, they don't really know what they've committed to until they're in production.

Some of those gambles pay off. Some become the jobs they wish they'd never won. And they can't tell the difference until it's too late.

> "Hopefully we make more on the good tenders to offset the money we lose on the bad tenders."

That's not a business strategy. That's a prayer.

The Wasted Estimator

The Cost

Estimators are highly paid specialists — £50-80k salaries.

They're trained to understand joinery, to value engineer, to find cost savings in designs, to source better materials, to spot where the margin can be improved.

The Reality

Instead, they spend nearly 100% of their time:

- Trawling through PDFs
- Cross-referencing specifications
- Copying and pasting into spreadsheets
- Looking up prices
- Manual data entry

They've been reduced to data entry clerks.

There's no satisfaction in trawling through various different formats of documents written by architects and trying to make sense of reference after reference.

The Waste

The business pays for value engineering and gets data entry.

How much time do they actually get to value engineer? Almost zero.

The deadline always wins.

What Value Engineering Actually Looks Like

When an estimator has the time and headspace to really think about a tender, they:

- Seek out cost savings in the design
- Find hidden components that can use cheaper materials
- Identify better construction approaches
- Source better materials
- Make recommendations to the client

They're not just pricing the job as specified. They're *improving* it.

Finding the places where the architect over-specified. Where a cheaper material would do the same job. Where a different approach to construction saves time on the floor. Where a better supplier changes the margin entirely.

That's not data entry. That's expertise applied.

That's the estimator saying "yes we can build what you drew, but here's how we'd build it *better and cheaper*."

That's value they can take to the main contractor. A competitive advantage. The difference between "here's our price" and "here's our price, and here's why we're the smarter choice."

The Informed and Trapped

The estimators know the value of their time and what they could achieve if they had the time to do it properly.

They can see the value they're not delivering. They know the savings they'd find. They watch tenders go out the door knowing they could have been better. And then the next PDF lands and it starts again.

That's not burnout from overwork. That's something sharper — the daily experience of your expertise being irrelevant.

The Bottleneck

Estimation is a sunk cost. Joineries have a bunch of estimators paid high salaries. The capacity of an estimator is

limited — and thus they are the bottleneck for future business.

10x the estimation capacity means 10x the potential business capacity.

Tenders they could win go unbid because there's no capacity to price them.

The Learned Helplessness

When asked if something needs to change, many joinery owners say: "*We're fine as we are*."

Said by a £50m joinery with a £500k gap they can't explain.

Normalised Blindness

Joineries are stuck in this way of working because they've accepted it as normal.

Estimates have lost their meaning. They're not estimating — they're just pricing. The word "estimate" has become synonymous with "price quote." There's no forecasting. No prediction of what it will actually take to deliver. Just a number to win the work.

Most don't track tender jobs through labour and believe it's arduous and time-consuming, not realising that measuring production and working backwards drives the healthiest margins.

The Probability Game

It becomes a probability game of "hopefully" vs "planned" profit.

Hopefully we make more on the good tenders to offset the money we lose on the bad tenders.

The Tender Win Rate Question

If you were to ask 10 joineries what their tender win rate is, none of them could answer.

They're bidding on jobs constantly. Winning some, losing some. But they can't tell you:

- The ratio
- Which types of jobs they win more often
- Which clients are worth pursuing
- Whether they're getting better or worse

They're playing poker without counting their chips.

Questions They Can't Answer

If we asked a joinery owner ten simple questions about their business, which ones would expose the blindness?

1. What's your tender win rate?

2. What's your average margin by job type?
3. Which customers are most profitable?
4. Which customers are least profitable?
5. How accurate are your estimates vs actual production time?
6. What's your capacity utilisation this month?
7. Which jobs should you have walked away from last year?
8. Where are your production bottlenecks?
9. How much does a cabinet carcass actually cost to make — materials, labour, margin?
10. Where are you losing money?

Every question should be easy. None of them are.

Part Three: The Category

What We're Creating

Estm8 isn't competing in an existing category. We're creating a new one.

The Existing Landscape

Below Us: Dated Joinery Tools

Clunky, dated tools that look and behave like Excel with buttons. Traditionally, joinery software is underserved. The software that does exist is very old and tired — rebadged Excel.

Built years ago. Never really evolved. The kind of software you tolerate, not use.

Above Us: Enterprise Construction Platforms

On the top end of the scale, there's tender management software for construction. But they serve other industries and require excessive consultancy and customisation for joineries.

Powerful but generic. To make them work for joinery, you need:

- Consultants to configure it
- Months to implement
- Payment for features you'll never touch

By the time it's working, the market has moved.

Alongside Us: Homegrown Spreadsheets

Most joineries run on homegrown Excel-based solutions — if a solution exists at all.

Familiar but fragile. Understood by one person. No visibility. No learning. No loop.

Profit management issues compound.

The Gap

Estm8 sits in the gap: **purpose-built for joinery, modern, no consultancy required.**

Our Category

Production-Connected Estimating for Bespoke Commercial Joinery

This is estimating that doesn't just win work — it forecasts it, tracks it, and proves it. It's the closed loop between quote and outcome that has never existed in this industry.

Alternative Framings

We might also describe this as:

Margin Visibility for Joinery Finally see where your money goes — from tender to completion.

Living Estimates Quotes that stay connected to reality as material costs shift and production unfolds.

The Closed Loop System Estimate → Produce → Measure → Learn → Improve

The Principle

Built on the principles of lean: **to improve, you must understand.**

The industry has accepted not understanding as normal. Estm8 makes understanding possible.

Part Four: The Solution

What Estm8 Does

Estm8 is a CRM, tender, and production management system for bespoke commercial joinery.

Instead of homegrown spreadsheets, it centralises all the information and provides meaningful dashboards about the joinery as a whole and specific tenders.

It assists joinery owners, estimators, and production teams in streamlining everything from enquiry to estimate to production. And by having a closed loop, it learns from the data to improve.

Two Views, One System

Revenue and Pipeline: Track enquiries, tenders, and won work.

Production and Labour: Track what actually happens on the floor.

These two views are connected. That's the breakthrough. The estimate feeds production. Production feeds back to the estimate. The loop closes.

Projects and Jobs

The system is designed in terms of projects and jobs.

Projects because a tender is a project at a specific point in time. It was once an enquiry but could move through to become won, and on to being a production project.

Jobs because tenders typically break into discrete jobs. Tenders may be won in full (all jobs won) or in part (some jobs won, others subcontracted to other joineries).

Guided Estimating

When a tender pack arrives, the estimator uploads it to Estm8.

The system reads drawings, interprets specification documents, and guides the estimator through producing the estimate.

When Drawings Are Clear

The system will try to make sense of drawings and correlate them to specifications. If the system can make sense of the drawings, it will produce an estimate for the estimator to review and amend.

When Drawings Are Complex

As with many drawings, they vary in quality. When the system cannot correlate or interpret the drawings reliably, it enters a supervised role.

The estimator is the eyes and articulates via voice or by typing the scope of the drawings. The system correlates these to the specifications.

The Jigsaw Solved

Either way, the jigsaw-building is handled. The estimator stays in their expertise — interpreting, judging, improving — while the system does the correlation and calculation.

AI as Background Component

The system uses AI assistants to help read drawings, interpret specifications, and rapidly produce estimates with live prices and measurable labour estimates.

But AI shouldn't be overstressed. Everything is talking AI at the moment — it's pure noise. We use AI but it's a background component. The system is built on it. It's a feature, not the story.

The Split

For the first time, every estimate shows the split: **materials, labour, margin.**

Not a guess. Not inherited from an old job. Actual numbers for this job.

The £500 cabinet question finally has an answer.

Traceable Prices

All prices are sourced from material suppliers with supporting links to the price. Every price is traceable — click the link, see where it came from.

Prices can be overridden when joineries negotiate bulk discounts from their own suppliers. The system gets more accurate as they use it.

Defensibility

Defensibility is key. This all ties back to the confidence that you understand exactly how an estimate was formed and can measure it.

The estimator can defend their numbers if challenged. The owner can see if they're overpaying vs market rates. When prices change, they can see what changed and by how much.

The Live Workspace

The estimate becomes a live workspace. Materials, labour, and margin can be modified.

The estimator can:

- Swap materials for cheaper alternatives
- Source from different suppliers
- Change construction methods
- Test margin scenarios
- See in real time how each decision moves the numbers

This is where value engineering actually happens — inside the estimate itself. Every tender becomes a chance to optimise, because you can finally see what you're optimising.

Live Pricing

To begin with, prices are sourced from the internet. This is deliberate — we need to create a compelling reason for suppliers to want to integrate with us. This then becomes another revenue stream.

If joineries are using Estm8 to make buying decisions based on internet prices, suppliers will want their actual prices in the system. Better visibility for the joinery, better positioning for the supplier, revenue stream for Estm8.

The network effect builds itself.

Production Tracking

Setup

Setup is simple: walk your production floor, list your machines and workstations.

This would range from drafting and setting out all the way through to machining and bench work.

The system maps to how your shop actually works. Not abstract project stages — real places where real work happens.

The Mobile App

Production teams log time via a mobile app. Very simple — they just log the job, the machine/workstation, and time.

Three taps: job, workstation, time. Back to work.

The Resistance

We expect resistance. The guys running the CNC or working the bench aren't sitting at computers. "I'm not filling in timesheets, I've got work to do."

Incentivisation

We believe incentivisation schemes will aid adoption. We'll work with joineries to build these.

Gamification techniques. Potentially performance bonuses — but we want to avoid manipulation, as performance bonuses may drive the wrong behaviour.

The Right Behaviour

The goal isn't fastest. It isn't most hours. The right behaviour is:

- **Honesty:** It took what it took, and now we know
- **Consistency:** Log it every time, no gaps

This is about improvement across the entire joinery, not blame on one person or workstation. It's about encouraging the identification and rectification of bottlenecks.

Protecting the Floor

If the estimate was wrong, the production data proves it wasn't the floor's fault — it was the quote.

The data isn't a weapon. It's a torch.

The Closed Loop

Pattern Recognition

When production data shows a pattern — bench work consistently runs 40% over estimate on a certain job type — the system flags it on the dashboard.

Action

This should trigger discussion and the potential for retrospective process review to understand why and how it can be mitigated.

The data is just the start. The value is what they do with it.

Supervised Updates

The system doesn't override expertise. Updates are supervised, not automatic.

The system identifies the pattern and asks whether they'd like to update the baseline. The senior estimator decides. Human decides. System records.

The Ledger

The system logs a full ledger of changes made to baselines.

Not just what the baselines are, but why they changed, when, and based on what.

The Guardian

The senior estimator becomes the guardian of the baselines. They're not being replaced by the system — they're being elevated. Their expertise now has a mechanism for being captured, tested, and passed on.

Compounding Intelligence

The more you use Estm8, the smarter your estimates get.

Not because of magic — because you're finally feeding reality back into the system.

A joinery using Estm8 for two years should be estimating more accurately than they were in month one.

The Speed

Tenders that currently take weeks can be completed in days or even hours.

The £150k Rescue

One joinery was about to walk away from a £150k bid because the specifications were so nested they were taking hours to even price a basic job.

The rational decision was to abandon it. £150k left on the table — not because the job was wrong, but because the process of understanding it was too expensive.

Estm8's specification analysis rescued it.

Before: 2 hours, one job not even partially complete. **After:** 2 hours, the entire tender priced.

Same two hours. Different reality.

He bid. He won. £150k recovered that would have been left on the floor.

The Capacity Unlock

That's not just efficiency. That's revenue recovered.

An estimator who completes two tenders a month could complete ten. Or twenty. The bottleneck doesn't just ease — it breaks open.

What They Do With Reclaimed Time

When tenders take hours instead of weeks, the estimator has capacity they've never had:

- **More tenders:** Bid on everything, grow the pipeline, win more work
- **Better tenders:** Finally do the value engineering, find the savings, sharpen the margins
- **Selectivity:** Actually choose which tenders are worth pursuing instead of just processing whatever lands

The Endgame

Production as the Honest Constraint

In an ideal scenario, estimation stops being the bottleneck. Production becomes the honest constraint — which it should be. That's real capacity, not administrative friction.

The Dashboard

When the owner looks at the dashboard, they don't see fog. They see:

> "We're maxed out on the CNC. Adding a second machine increases capacity by 30%. Here's the payback period based on current tender flow."

Business Clarity

That's not estimating software. That's a business clarity tool.

The owner knows exactly where growth is constrained and what it would take to unlock it.

No Consultancy Required

The Red Flag

"No consultancy" is very important. It's a major red flag for joineries. They want to see results fast.

It's far better to have minor onboarding and self-directed setup than lengthy customisation and implementation.

Enterprise tools have burned them with six-month implementations and consultants who don't understand joinery.

The Speed

"Start Monday, see results by Friday" is more compelling than any feature list.

What Setup Looks Like

Set up users. Walk your production floor to set up machinery. Create companies and contacts. Create a tender and assign it. Start estimating.

Import tools will exist but we don't expect standard formats, so they'll be built over time.

The setup *is* the work. Not configuration before work — just starting.

The system doesn't ask them to learn its world. It asks them to describe their world. And from that, it starts to show them things they've never seen.

Part Five: The Story

Origin

Estm8 wasn't built by software people who studied the problem. It was built by a joiner who lived it.

The co-founder runs a joinery. He built this system because he needed it. His shop runs this way. It works.

Weathering the Storm

When the market turned brutal — when nearly 4,000 construction companies went under in a year — his joinery could weather it.

Because he can see. He knows, before he commits to a tender, what's margin and what's gamble.

He can see the risk and avoid it.

The £150k Rescue

He was about to walk away from a £150k bid. The specifications were so nested they were taking hours just to understand a single job. The rational decision was to abandon it.

Estm8's specification analysis rescued it. Same two hours — the entire tender priced instead of one job partially understood.

He bid. He won. £150k recovered that would have been left on the floor.

The visibility didn't just protect him from a bad tender. It unlocked a good one he would have abandoned.

The Earned Right to Challenge

The challenging voice has earned the right to challenge.

This isn't software people who studied the problem. This is a joiner who built the solution because he needed it. His shop runs this way. It works.

"We know where the money goes. Do you?"

That's a different challenge when it comes from someone who actually runs a shop.

The Mission

Transform an industry that's suffering.

The vision is big: joineries that can see their entire business clearly for the first time. But the website isn't a manifesto — it's a door.

The first belief that gets them through:

> You can finally see where your money goes.

The full vision is too big for the first conversation. But people need a story to believe in. This is the story we want — to transform an industry that's suffering.

Once they're through the door — once they're an early adopter, once they're seeing results — the bigger story unfolds. They discover the production tracking. Then the dashboards. Then the baseline learning. Then one day they realise they can see their whole business clearly.

Legacy

The £50m joinery owner talked about legacy. Passing the business to the next generation. He knew technology would have a key part to play.

There was no fear in it. He knew he was long in the tooth, so to speak, and that the newer people around him — more open to technology — would benefit. He'd like them to take the joinery into the future.

The Gap Between Generations

Thirty years of knowing what a cabinet should cost. Knowing which contractors pay on time. Knowing where the bottlenecks show up. Knowing which jobs to walk away from.

All locked in his head.

When he hands over the keys, he's handing over a business that only worked because he was there to feel his way through it.

The next generation won't have 30 years of gut. They'll have data, or they'll have nothing.

The Cliff vs The Handover

Between him and the "newer people who are more open to technology" — is there a handover? Or is there a cliff?

Right now, his 30 years of knowledge exists as intuition. It's not captured anywhere. When he steps back:

- Do the younger estimators know *why* £500 was the right number?
- Do they know which contractors to avoid?
- Do they know where the bottlenecks will show up before they show up?

Or do they just inherit a business that looks healthy on paper, with a £500k gap they won't find for another two years?

Knowledge That Doesn't Walk Out the Door

The ledger is legacy.

When the 30-year veteran steps back, the next generation doesn't just inherit gut feel and folklore. They inherit a documented record of decisions.

"In March 2026, we updated bench work estimates for hardwood cabinets by 15% because production data showed consistent overruns on complex grain matching."

The knowledge doesn't walk out the door. It's in the system.

Estm8 is how 30 years of knowledge becomes visible — so it can be passed on.

Part Six: The Audience

Primary Buyer: The Owner

The owner has the budget and the authority. They're watching margins erode and can't figure out why. They've hired business analysts to find gaps they should have seen themselves.

What They Say

"We're fine as we are."

What They Feel

Uncertainty they can't admit. The sense that something is off but no way to see what.

They've normalised flying blind. They call it estimating but it's just pricing. Pricing with no understanding of what the job will actually cost to deliver.

The Identity Shield

Thirty years of expertise used as a blindfold.

The £500 gut-call isn't just a pricing method — it's proof of their expertise. Challenge the process and you threaten the identity.

But they hired a business analyst. They know something's off. They just can't trace it back to their own decisions.

What They Need

To be challenged — without being insulted.

Their 30 years of expertise respected, while the fog is named.

Not "you're wrong." But "you're flying a plane with no instruments, and you're good enough that you've survived — but you shouldn't have to."

What They Want to Hear

- The firms that survive will be the ones that can see
- Your expertise shouldn't be trapped in your head
- This is an investment in the future, not a criticism of the past

Champion: The Younger Estimator

The younger estimators are digitally present (active on LinkedIn — a good indicator of technology adeptness), frustrated, and open to technology. They see the potential. They have influence but need to sell internally.

What They Say

"I don't have enough time."

What They Feel

Trapped. Informed and trapped.

They can see the value they're not delivering. They know the savings they'd find if they had time. They watch tenders go out the door knowing they could have been better. And then the next PDF lands and it starts again.

That's not burnout from overwork. That's the daily experience of your expertise being irrelevant.

What They Want

They want to value engineer.

They didn't spend years learning joinery to become PDF processors. They want to do the work that actually matters — finding smarter ways to build, spotting cost savings, making the tender better, not just done.

What They Resonated With

Excitement and a vision for the future. They saw the potential in the prototype.

They all understand the data clerk issue. No satisfaction in trawling through various formats of documents.

What They Need

Validation. A vision for what their role could be. The language and evidence to make the case upward.

What They Asked For

Side-by-side comparison against old jobs. Show them what they didn't see.

They made this very clear. That's the proof point. Not a demo of features. Not a dashboard walkthrough. Real jobs they've already done, shown back to them differently.

"Here's Job X. You priced it at £500. Here's what Estm8 would have shown you. Here's what it actually cost. Here's where the margin went."

Suddenly the £500k gap isn't abstract. It's *this* job. And *that* job. Jobs they remember.

The Decision Dynamic

The owner has the budget but not the urgency.
The estimator has the urgency but not the budget.

The website needs to do two things:

1. **Arm the estimator** — give them the language and logic to make the case upward
2. **Reassure the owner** — make it feel like an investment in the future, not a criticism of the past

The Internal Sales Conversation

When the younger estimator goes to the 30-year veteran and says "I found something," what questions will the owner ask?

- What does it actually do?
- How much?
- How long before we see results?
- Is it going to disrupt everything?
- Will I have to learn a new system?
- Does it work with how we already do things?

The website can pre-answer these objections through the estimator — give them the confidence and the language. The estimator becomes our inside champion.

Production Teams

Not buyers. Not champions. But critical to success.

If production data doesn't flow back, the loop stays open.

What They Fear

"Management watching me."

What They Need to Believe

"Finally I can prove where the time actually goes."

If the estimate was wrong, this proves it wasn't my fault — it was the quote.

Part Seven: Messaging Framework

The Core Question

Do you know where you're losing money?

Six words. And they can't say yes.

Not "are you losing money" — they know they are. Not "how much" — that's abstract. *Where*.

The £50m owner doesn't know. The estimator doesn't know. The business analyst was hired because nobody knows.

If you don't know where, you can't fix it. You can only hope.

The First Belief

You can finally see where your money goes.

This is the door. Not speed. Not AI. Not transformation. Visibility.

The £500 cabinet where he couldn't say what was materials, labour, or margin. The £500k gap. The jobs that go in and come out with no understanding of what happened in between.

Every joinery owner has felt the money leaking. They just can't see where.

The First Moment of Truth

The first estimate where they see the material/labour/margin split clearly.

Before production tracking. Before dashboards. Before they've changed anything about how they work. One tender in Estm8 and they see what they've never seen.

The emotional response: **excitement.**

Not dread at what they'll find. Excitement at finally being able to see.

That's significant. The emotional journey isn't "face the painful truth." It's "gain a superpower you never had."

The Promise Progression

Door: You can finally see where your money goes.

First Value: The split — materials, labour, margin — on your first estimate.

Growing Value: Tenders in hours instead of weeks. Time to actually value engineer.

Deep Value: Production tracked. Estimates measured against reality. Patterns surfaced.

Full Vision: See your entire business clearly. Know exactly where growth is constrained and what it would take to unlock it.

Supporting Messages

For the Owner

- You've been in this game for 30 years. Can you tell me what's material, labour, and margin on that cabinet?
- Your expertise shouldn't be trapped in your head
- The market isn't the problem. It's revealing what was always there
- The firms that survive will be the ones that can see
- You're not bad at estimating. You're just doing it blind.

For the Estimator

- You didn't train for years to copy-paste from PDFs
- Weeks to hours. Same tender. Different reality.
- Finally do the value engineering you were hired for
- Your estimates don't just win work. They prove it.
- The jigsaw is solved. Stay in your expertise.

On the Problem

- Jobs go in. Jobs go out. What happens in between is invisible.
- You call them estimates. They're just prices.
- Hopefully is not a margin strategy.
- You're not losing money somewhere. You're losing it everywhere you're not looking.
- The £500 cabinet is a memory of a different job with a guess on top.

On the Solution

- Start Monday. See results by Friday.
- No consultants. No six-month implementations. Just start.
- Built by a joiner. For joineries.
- The system learns from your work. The more you use it, the smarter it gets.
- The loop closes. Estimate, produce, measure, learn, improve.

On Speed

- What used to take weeks now takes hours.
- Same two hours. One job partially understood vs entire tender priced.
- The bottleneck breaks open.

On Legacy

- Your 30 years of knowledge shouldn't walk out the door with you.
- The next generation won't have your gut. They'll have data, or they'll have nothing.
- Make your expertise visible so it can be passed on.

Part Eight: Voice & Tone

Who's Speaking

An insider. A joiner who's seen enough shops to know the truth. Who's built a business that runs differently. Who has earned the right to challenge.

Not software people who studied the problem. A joiner who lived it.

The Posture

Challenging.

Not aggressive. Not arrogant. But willing to say the uncomfortable thing plainly.

"You've been in this game for 30 years. Can you tell me what's material, what's labour, and what's margin on that cabinet?"

Respect for the craft, but no patience for the fog.

The Register

Plain-spoken.

No jargon. No fluff. Say it straight.

These aren't tech people. They're tradespeople. They'll smell bullshit instantly.

Words We Use

- Margin
- Carcass
- Setting out
- Labour
- Shop
- Supplier
- Tender
- Job
- Takeoff
- Bench work
- Drawings

- Specs

Words We Avoid

- Workflow
- Leverage
- Synergy
- Streamline
- Optimise
- AI-powered
- Cutting-edge
- Revolutionary
- Transform (in isolation)
- Solution
- Platform

British English

- Labour, not labor
- Colour, not color
- Specialise, not specialize
- Analyse, not analyze
- Recognise, not recognize

Tone Principles

- Warm but direct
- Confident without arrogance
- Challenging without condescending
- Plain language, no hiding
- Respect for the craft
- Impatience with the fog
- Honest about what we don't know yet (early adopter framing)

Part Nine: The Offer

The Invitation

We're building this for joineries like you. Help us shape it.

Honest. Filters for the right people.

The owner who says "we're fine as we are" won't respond. But the estimator who's frustrated, the younger team that sees a better way, the owner who's tired of the fog — they might want to be part of building something.

What Early Adopters Get

- **Founding customer discount** — a rate that locks in
- **Influence** — their feedback genuinely shapes the roadmap
- **Access** — first to get new features, direct line to the team
- **Results** — if Estm8 delivers, they're ahead of competitors who waited

The Price

Starting at £1,200/month.

A subscription that includes a number of seats and a number of projects/jobs. (Still determining exact thresholds — need more data points from early adopters.)

The Value Math

Against an estimator at £50-80k, that's 18-25% of the salary cost.

If Estm8 gives that estimator even 30% more capacity, it's paid for itself.

If it catches one bad tender that would have lost £20k, it's paid for itself.

Against a £500k gap — it's a rounding error.

The Competitive Alternative

What they do instead:

Hire estimators: £50-80k each. More capacity to process tenders blindly. More guesses, faster. The same inherited pricing, the same disconnection from production, just at greater volume.

Hire business analysts: £50-80k. Someone to find the damage after it's done. Paid to excavate the gap that better visibility would have prevented in the first place.

Three-person workaround: £150-240k/year to manage a broken system. And they still have a £500k gap.

Estm8 costs less than the people they're hiring to work around not having it. And it actually fixes the problem instead of scaling the blindness or reporting on it after the fact.

The Speed to Value

How fast could a joinery go from "yes" to "using it"?

Very fast. That's the point.

No consultants. No complex setup. No six-month implementations.

Set up users. Walk your production floor to set up machinery. Create companies and contacts. Create a tender. Start estimating.

The setup is the work. Not configuration before work — just starting.

What We Need to Learn

The open questions that real usage will answer:

- How many tenders does a typical joinery run per month?
- How many users actually need access?
- Where does the system break or confuse people?
- What features are missing that they expected?
- How long before production teams actually adopt the time logging?
- What does the value engineering payoff actually look like in practice?
- What's the right seat/project threshold for pricing tiers?

Part Ten: The Competitive Landscape

Why Now

The market is hard. This is perhaps the hardest point.

But hard markets don't create new problems. They expose the ones you were already ignoring.

In good times, blind tendering is survivable. The wins paper over the losses. You don't need to see clearly because there's enough work to absorb the mistakes.

In hard times, the margin for error disappears. Every tender you win at the wrong price actively hurts you. Every tender you could have bid on but didn't because your estimators were buried — that's growth you'll never get back.

The market isn't the problem. It's revealing what was always there.

The Software Landscape

Below: Dated Joinery Tools

- Look and behave like rebadged Excel
- Built years ago, never evolved
- Tolerated, not used
- No visibility, no learning, no loop

Above: Enterprise Construction Platforms

- Built for main contractors, not joineries
- Require excessive consultancy and customisation
- Months to implement
- Pay for features you'll never use
- By the time it's working, the market has moved

Alongside: Homegrown Spreadsheets

- The default
- Familiar but fragile
- Understood by one person
- No visibility, no learning, no loop
- Profit management issues compound

The Gap

Estm8 sits in the gap:

- Purpose-built for joinery
- Modern
- No consultancy required
- The closed loop that has never existed

The Headcount Alternative

More Estimators

£50-80k each. More capacity to process tenders blindly. More guesses, faster.

The same inherited pricing. The same disconnection from production. Just at greater volume.

Scales the blindness.

Business Analysts

£50-80k. Someone to find the damage after it's done.

Paid to excavate the £500k gap that better visibility would have prevented in the first place.

Reports on the wreckage.

Neither Closes the Loop

Neither creates understanding. One adds capacity to a broken process. The other audits the wreckage.

Estm8 actually fixes the problem.

Part Eleven: Early Adopter Strategy

Target: LinkedIn Estimators

There are a lot of estimators on LinkedIn. This is a good indicator of technology adeptness.

They've self-selected as digitally present. They're probably the same profile as the younger estimators who got excited by the prototype.

What Makes Them Stop Scrolling

- Validation of their frustration: "You trained for years, not to copy-paste from PDFs"
- A vision of what their role could be: "Estimators as strategic, not clerical"
- Curiosity about something new: "We're building something — want in?"
- Status: "Be one of the first to try this"

The Estimator's Emotional State

Quietly frustrated? Openly frustrated? Just getting on with it?

They're informed and trapped. They can see the value they're not delivering. They watch tenders go out the door knowing they could have been better.

The message that stops them isn't always the most logical one. It's the one that names something they've been avoiding.

Arming the Champion

The estimator might need to feel *seen* before they feel sold to.

Then we arm them to sell internally:

- The language to make the case
- The logic to answer the owner's questions
- The confidence to say "I found something, we need to look at this"

What They Asked For

Side-by-side comparison against old jobs.

Not a demo. Not a sales call. Real jobs they've already done, shown back to them differently.

"Here's Job X. You priced it at £500. Here's what Estm8 would have shown you. Here's what it actually cost. Here's where the margin went."

The website doesn't need to convince anyone of anything. It just needs to get them to say: "Here's one of our old jobs. Show us."

The Conversion Mechanism

Once they see their own numbers in the system — their own jobs, their own margins, their own blind spots — the £500k gap isn't abstract anymore.

It's *this* job. And *that* job. Jobs they remember.

That's not a sales tool. That's the entire conversion mechanism.

Summary

The Problem (Named)

Blind Tendering — the industry-wide practice of pricing jobs with no forecast of actual production costs. They call it "estimating" but they're just pricing. The number wins the work. What it costs to deliver remains invisible until it's too late.

The Category (Created)

Production-Connected Estimating — estimates that don't just win work, they forecast it, track it, and prove it. The closed loop between quote and outcome.

The Core Question

Do you know where you're losing money?

The Promise

You can finally see where your money goes.

The Proof

A joiner built this system because he needed it. His shop weathers the storm because he can see the risk before he commits. Now he's offering that sight to others.

The Offer

We're building this for joineries like you. Help us shape it.

The Principle

To improve, you must understand.

Estm8. See where your money goes.